The decision to actually take up arms may have been accelerated because of the deepening economic troubles related to the global depression. Market prices were in sharp decline and peasants' request for a postponement of tax collection was denied. San's charismatic appeal and forceful rhetoric probably helped to further promote the cause.

San used secret societies and traditional symbolism to promote the rebellion. The galon, a mythical bird, became the main rallying symbol for the resistance. The colonial opposition was referred to as nagas or snakes. The resistance army tattooed with the galon and a secret oath would be sworn. Many of San's followers used amulets and charms that they believed made them impervious from bullets. San proclaimed the capital at Alan Taung (renaming it Buddha Raja).

The rebels attacked government outposts in the Tharrawaddy area, but ultimately spread elsewhere. San's forces were poorly armed in comparison to the seasoned colonial fighters. The British called in reinforcements from India as San's army rapidly fell apart. Not only were casualties mounting from the fighting, but they also were decimated by disease.

San was forced to flee to the northern Shan state in a futile attempt to ferment rebellion among some of the ethnic minorities. In August, San was captured and over a period of several months the remaining resistance forces were destroyed. A special tribunal was established and convicted San, who was executed in December 1931. San became a martyr for Burmese nationalism. The movement fueled the fire of nationalism and put the vernacular press in a more active role. The harsh response from the British authorities played into the hands of nationalist agitators.

Overall, the rebellion was the result of the interaction of various factors, including political ferment, national consciousness, economic distress, opposition to taxation, and racial bias against foreigners. The momentum created by the insurrection heightened tensions as well as providing momentum for additional nationalist movements. The British were now forced to pay closer attention to the situation in Burma. Ultimately a new breed of younger nationalists known as the Thakin emerged on the scene.

NATIONALISM: POST SAN REBELLION